prominence in vulnerable states like Barbados (Clark and Zucker 2024). IOs also invest in online communication strategies and centralize their public messaging to ensure consistency and effectiveness (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018b; Bjola and Zaiotti 2020; Özdemir and Rauh 2022).

TABLE 7.1. Growth in Twitter followers of most-followed IOs

International Organization (IO)	Follower count (2017)	Follower count (2022)	Growth (% Increase)
United Nations	9.3 million	15.9 million	70.9%
UNICEF	6.3 million	9.3 million	47.6%
World Health Organization	3.9 million	11.8 million	202.6%
World Wildlife Fund	3.7 million	3.9 million	5.4%
Human Rights Watch	3.5 million	5 million	42.9%
World Economic Forum	3.1 million	4.2 million	35.5%
UNESCO	2.7 million	3.6 million	33.3%
World Bank	2.5 million	3.7 million	48%
Total	35 million	57.4 million	64%

Sources: Authors collected 2022 data from Twitter; historical data from Twiplomacy (2017).

The widespread presence of IOs on social media underscores their commitment to engaging with global audiences. For example, a 2016 study identified ninety-seven institutional accounts and seventy-four personal accounts of IO leaders, collectively boasting more than 64 million followers. These accounts include major organizations like the UN, UNICEF, WHO, and the World Bank, alongside high-profile leaders such as NATO's Jens Stoltenberg and former IMF managing director Christine Lagarde (Twiplomacy 2017). Table 7.1 highlights the continued growth of IO social media followings, demonstrating their enduring popularity.

Interestingly, IOs' social media audiences are not primarily composed of elites. A cursory analysis of IMF and World Bank followers reveals that fewer than 1 percent of these users are verified accounts, indicating that most followers are everyday citizens rather than prominent public figures or policymakers.[8]